

Berkeley Neighbors for Housing & Climate Action 2024 Candidate Questionnaire

Candidate Name: Todd Andrew

District / Office being sought: Council District 5

1. Berkeley's Housing Element lays out the city's plan for new housing construction through 2031, ensuring the city can meet its Regional Housing Needs Allocation (RHNA) of ~9,000 homes across a range of income levels.

The Housing Element commits Berkeley to a number of major policy changes in order to meet state requirements for affirmatively furthering fair housing, including citywide zoning for "missing middle" housing, a San Pablo Specific Plan, an updated Demolition Ordinance, and upzoning along North Shattuck, Solano, and College Ave, among other items.

What is your view on the Housing Element and these policies? What are the most important things we need to do to implement the City's Housing Element?

Please discuss your ideas and priorities around:

- a. Missing Middle housing

I support Council's recent Arreguin/Kesarwani motion that was passed by council in July, including awaiting the evacuation study before taking action in the Hillside Overlay Zone and other amendments for the rest of the city.

- b. San Pablo specific plan

As a Berkeleyan, I am embarrassed for our progressive city that the San Pablo Avenue Corridor Project major transit and street safety improvements will end four blocks into South Berkeley. On the wider questions, we need to ensure the plan recognizes historical inequities and the transit-oriented nature of the corridor, encourages new housing and complies with state law.

- c. Zoning for housing in high-resource neighborhoods like North Shattuck, Solano, and College Ave

I support the Housing Element amendment put forth by Councilmember Kesarwani (Taplin?) to Affirmatively Further Fair Housing in these resource-rich corridors. In addition to equity, I believe new housing will help to revitalize these corridors and the small businesses in them that help to make Berkeley the unique place to live that it is.

2. Berkeley's Climate Action Plan sets forth a goal of 80% reduction in greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions by 2050. Today, the two major sources of GHG emissions in Berkeley are from gas-powered automobiles and natural gas used in buildings.

Berkeley has a variety of plans and programs intended to help address these emissions, including the Electric Mobility Roadmap and the Berkeley Existing Building Electrification Strategy. Other related efforts include the Bicycle Plan and Pedestrian Master Plan, as well as the City's now-defunct natural gas ban on new buildings. Upcoming policy initiatives include the Berkeley Building Electrification and Just Transition Pilot Program, Measure GG, the Bay Area Air Quality Management District's regional ban on new NOx-emitting appliances, and more.

What is your view on the Climate Action Plan and these strategies? What are the most important things we need to do to address greenhouse gas emissions?

Please discuss your ideas and priorities around how Berkeley can reduce emissions from transportation and buildings, and how we should align the climate transition with our other goals as a city.

Our climate action framework needs to be consistent with global, national and local climate objectives, to improve health outcomes as well as to address climate change. In my view, our progressive city at times exhibits small "c" conservative resistance to proven strategies, especially around housing and transportation. We need to do everything we can to empathetically engage our neighbors, especially the disabled and elderly, and communicate the virtual necessity of actions, many of which have concurrent benefits around the reduction of serious injury and death on our streets.

It's my understanding our new building natural gas ban wouldn't have been challenged in court, with the negative outcome based on federal law and the expenditures entailed in its defense, had we compromised on a ground level commercial exemption. That is disappointing.

As the state moves forward with a ban on gas-powered cars, and as we move forward with existing building electrification, we need to have the vision to plan for an all-electric future that takes into account the needs of low-income people where economic imperatives will interfere with their transition, and that doesn't add yet another impediment to new housing.

3. In your opinion, what was the most important City Council vote on Berkeley's housing crisis in the past four years? Briefly describe the issue, what you think of the Council's decision, and what you would have done had you been on the Council. For incumbents, please describe why you voted the way you did, and what you think now about that vote.

I was impressed with the leadership of some councilmembers toward a compliant Housing Element, that includes serious proposals to meet our RHNA objectives and keeps us out of "builders remedy" territory, even in the face of some local leaders who seemed to consider it to be more of an academic exercise.

4. In your opinion, what was the most important climate or environmental issue faced by the Berkeley City Council in the last four years? Briefly describe the issue, what you think of the

Council's decision, and what you would have done had you been on the Council. For incumbents, please describe why you voted the way you did, and what you think now about that vote.

In my view, in addition to many other things, Measure L was a climate change initiative. It's too bad it was combined into one omnibus measure addressing such a broad range of issues, including affordable housing, rather than being separated into components that gave Berkeleyans a chance to express meaningful preferences. Although it wasn't perfect, the process and results around BUSD's Measure G Facilities Bond in 2020 was better.

5. To achieve its RHNA goals, Berkeley must continue to build homes for all income levels. These new residents will need to travel within Berkeley. Greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions from transportation comprise roughly 60% of total emissions in Berkeley.

How would you ensure that Berkeley continues to reduce GHG emissions while adding new homes?

Similar to other areas of policy, in my view, we need to follow through on our good intentions and do what we say we're going to do. In this case, that means acting on our Bike, Pedestrian, Vision Zero, Complete Streets and Climate Action plans. I hope to have many conversations with District 5 residents in the coming years about the win-win-win when residents have as many safe, reliable, accessible transportation options as possible that reduce traffic and parking problems, and also serious injuries, deaths and greenhouse gas emissions.

Though I realize transit advocates have reservations, I would like to see us study a small scale shuttle that has these qualities, and will perhaps be more likely to encourage residents to experiment with non-private car travel. We have local models we can study, such as the Emery GoRound, Cal and West Berkeley/Bayer/Wareham shuttles, as well as the Metro Micro in Los Angeles.

6. Walking and biking presents opportunities to help Berkeley residents reduce their GHG emissions, but safety concerns can be a major deterrent. Of the two competing street paving measures on the ballot this November, one of the major differences between the two is the approach to funding safety improvements for walking and biking.

Measure EE would provide safety funding only for traffic calming on bicycle boulevards and major pedestrian projects identified in the Pedestrian Plan. Measure FF would provide funding to implement safety measures throughout the city, based on existing plans.

What is your perspective on how we should address pedestrian and cyclist safety on our streets? What is your perspective on these two measures?

I support Measure FF as the more comprehensive, and thus necessary, approach to street rehabilitation in Berkeley. We have data, both local (e.g., Rose Street) and beyond our borders,

that unequivocally shows streets become less safe when they are repaved without a broad range of safety improvements, and that these steps improve safety for **everyone**, including motorists.

7. Berkeley has a long history of using zoning, restrictive covenants and redlining to achieve racial and economic segregation. This history continues to shape Berkeley today.

Recent research by the Turner Center at UC Berkeley suggests that inclusionary zoning requirements, which mandate on-site restricted affordable housing in new developments, may have the effect of reducing overall housing construction, including the production of affordable units. However, on-site affordable housing can also be an effective tool for desegregating neighborhoods.

What is your perspective on how Berkeley should use inclusionary zoning requirements, versus other affordable housing development options (such as in-lieu fees)?

I am generally in favor of measures that expand housing opportunity with an “all of the above” approach, including options for non-inclusionary as well as inclusionary units. The Housing Trust Fund has been a valuable source of funds for affordable housing in Berkeley, using in-lieu fees that can be leveraged four to five times to build affordable housing.

8. Many of the highest income neighborhoods in Berkeley are also in the Hillside Overlay, portions of which are in the California Very High Fire Hazard Severity Zone (CalFire VHFHSZ). How should we balance fire risk with affirmatively furthering fair housing?

We seem to have semi-regular brouhahas over new housing in fire severity zones, including ADUs and Middle Housing, and then go back to doing things the same way. I fear we may be whistling past the graveyard.

On both issues, Fire Chief Sprague has written memos that outline severe **current** dangers, not just with the addition of new homes. These dangers are focused on structure footprint, proximity and number; cars; and people. While I appreciate the need for an evacuation study, I fear it may not be comprehensive enough. In my view, a comprehensive approach would examine the need to address the current risks as well, which may illuminate how we can safely add new housing, most of which since 2008 has been much more fire resistant than structures built before 2008. I would also like us to evaluate fire equipment (i.e., vehicle) purchases to ensure we build our emergency response fleet around our city rather than the other way around.